Third, pilgrimages of various faiths intensified during the medieval period. French traveller Jean-Baptiste Tavernier in the 17th century observed a band of 4000 pilgrims in India travelling without prior food arrangements, conveying both scale and logistical possibilities.[57] Pilgrimage-associated trade in south India led to temple-generated urbanization, benefiting merchants and artisans.[58] New routes were developed for more recent faiths such as the overseas Hajj pilgrimage from Surat for the Muslims and the Bhakti, Sufi, and Sikh religious and spiritual movements. There was also the immigration of Christian missionaries from Europe, initially to Goa which was ruled by the Portuguese since the 16th century. The share of the Muslim population in the Indian subcontinent rose substantially in the western and eastern wings due to the 'creative adaptation' of migrants and newly settled peasants who were not necessarily a part of entrenched Hindu societies, while the share of Christians in Goa rose on account of conversion.[59] Migrations in the medieval period were therefore at the intersection of complex military, commercial and religious networks. Some of these migrations, especially those of the military and merchants, are recounted in greater detail later, but there are a few direct references on migration in the medieval period that deserve special mention.

The first was to do with the rise and fall of cities in the medieval period. In the 17th century, at least nine cities were known to have populations exceeding 2,00,000 people: Agra, Delhi, Lahore, Thatta (Sindh), Ahmedabad, Surat, Patna, Dacca and Masulipatnam (a port on the east coast).[60] These were large city sizes for their time, drawing a large number of merchants and artisans. Since many cities were built from scratch, they also required migrants to populate their activities. In some places like Uttar Pradesh, there was an established practice of recruiting migrants from beyond the Indus.[61] There are records of migrants from Afghanistan and Bukhara (Uzbekistan) being brought to Shahjahanpur in the 17th century, and more from Afghanistan to Rohilkhand (around Bareilly) in the 18th century. There are also records of rulers willingly moving en masse to another place, as in the infamous case of Muhammad bin Tughlaq's move